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Under a Curtain of Stars

Author:

Matt Mills

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“Under a Curtain of Stars”

by Matt Mills

Former astronaut SAM FOWLER, determined but haunted, wanders their study, trying to focus on reality in front of some guests.

Clouds, trees, mountains, oceans… I’m here, I’m home, I’m back on Earth. Breathe in. Smell the ground, the water, the planet at my feet. Feel the weight of it pulling closer. That great, inescapable weight. Focus, focus… no stars—no, no, not the black abyss. Come back. Get back. Trees, birds, bugs, dirt…

Bring me back. So far, I always manage to come back. But just barely. And a little less every time.

How are you sure where you are at any given moment? Have you never had to think about it? When you can no longer trust your senses, what can you trust? I can only seem to find a little trust in the trees. In the dirt. The grime that once was a nuisance becomes like a friend. A familiar reminder of where you are. This way lie the gross delicacies only our Earth could provide. That inevitable nature, usually so uninvited and unwanted, becomes your only solace. Dirt, bugs, smoke, mud…

I left the planet fifteen months ago; my body returned six months after that, but my mind is still trying to land. It can’t help but drift weightlessly, halfway between space and Earth, the border between the two constantly eroding. I… I feel myself floating through the hallways, struggling to clamp down framed photos, losing control of my momentum…

It’s not news to anybody that astronauts need time for their organs to reacclimate when they return from space, bone densities shifting with our corner of the universe. Muscles returning to bear the load of a life on this heavy planet. But my muscles are fine. My bones are as strong as iron. The last organ I need to reacclimate… is my brain. And I don’t know if I can.

The sun shines so coldly I can hardly wake up. I wheeze for breath but it’s somehow too much and too little at the same time. Food’s no better—it’s all either too intense or it may as well be water. I’m never solid; I’m stuck between two stratospheres, clinging to scraps of a life that I may never be able to live again.

I struggle to trust my family. I’m not sure any of us are the same people anymore. I’m not even sure any of us are actually here… I know I touched my partner’s hand when I came home, and I remember it getting colder and colder until it wasn’t there. It faded and so did my trust of

the ground I walk on. Now I'm stuck. Stuck nowhere—just me and the two stratospheres trying to make a home out of confusion.

When was the last time you felt truly alone? Truly lost? When was the last time you doubted you'd ever make it back? Did it make you appreciate the familiar things more? Or did you just keep… floating away? Without a tether. I've lost mine. I keep floating away and there's nothing left to pull me back.

Nothing but clouds, trees, mountains, oceans… it's all supposed to be familiar, but the more used to this place I get, the stranger I feel. I'm not the same person that was invited here years ago. I feel like an intruder. A separate entity crashing a planetary party, still waiting for an invitation. I'm not sure that it's coming. Stars, stars…

Flowers, mud, oceans… the first time I laid eyes on our planet I couldn't believe it. She looked so beautiful from up high, a peaceful blue pool beneath our feet, like the Atlantic was made for us to dip our toes in. The sun shines so… unencumbered and free, looking like an unshakable king of our solar system. Every star still distant, but now, so unique and unafraid. It's daunting. It's heartbreaking. That beauty so astounding it's unlike anything you've ever felt before or will feel again. And it becomes your new world. It *is* our world. It was mine. But I have to get back. I need to focus on the flowers, the mud, the oceans…

Dirt, water, trees… the night is the worst part. Stuck in this black shell of a house with nothing to see from the windows but stars? I'm sent right back to that lonely, cold can thousands of miles away from home. Hundreds of miles away from air. From trees, dirt… The isolation consumes me; it needs me; it feeds on me. Morning always finds me half-eaten—searching for grass, birds, sprinklers, gardens… The white-dotted black curtains of my eyelids always present, even when the gold daylight shines through. Stars, black abyss, galactic dust, no gravity, black abyss, black void, black void… Dirt. Dirt, trees, mountains, cl– clou– cl–...

Swirl of confusion comes to a rest and resets.

Why? Why. Why can't… Why can't I just… reprogram my brain? It seems so easy. Just commit to saying, 'This is the sky high above you; the ground is yours to keep.' Why-why won't my mind listen to itself? Why do we live in these… these fragile, lifelong traps? I want to think. I want to feel. I want to breathe. I want to take a step without worrying it'll be my last. I need to know: I'm home; I'm safe. But it doesn't feel that way. I don't feel that way. I don't feel safe. I doubt I ever will. I feel borrowed. I feel stolen. Ripped from the universe—thrown around to never return again. Why can't I feel okay?! I have degrees in engineering, mathematics… I can't figure it out. I can't solve it. I can't get out. I can't trust myself. I can't trust anything. I can't

escape. There's nowhere for me to go; this is the end. I can't… I've got to… I've got… I've got to… stars, black void, black void, black void, black void…

They hyperventilate and drop, catching the edge of a couch to stop the fall.

I apologize… I thought today might be a day for progress. But progress doesn't seem to be on its way. At least not imminently. But. I appreciate you trying to bring me out of this. I guess… Space isn't done with me yet. It won't let me go. Please do return, though—maybe by then, the ground will feel more like my home, and not… I… I… clouds, trees, mountains, oceans. Grass, birds, sprinklers, gardens. Dirt, smoke, mud, flowers, clouds, trees…